

A matter of code

After discovering the convenience and security which a coded message provided, most English kings began to write in cipher. Charles I was the monarch who made the most use of ciphers during his reign. During their separation, Charles I and Queen Henrietta Maria used complicated ciphers to correspond.

Charles I used many different ciphers during the period of 1640 to 1650 to communicate sensitive information. His recipients included Prince Rupert, the Parliament General and ministers in Oxford.



Marie Antoinette

French connection

The highly controversial Queen of France and Navarre, Marie Antoinette relied on ciphers to communicate with Count Axel von Fersen after their flight to Varennes.

At the height of the French Revolution in 1791, King Louis XVI and Queen Marie Antoinette escaped France in disguise. But they were detected and detained at the town of Varennes and returned to Tuileries Palace. Count Axel von Fersen, a Swede, was an accomplice who worked disguised as a coachman in Paris. The next day, he got the information of their failure. Fersen then communicated with Marie Antoinette from Brussels in cipher. Marie wrote back indicating that she was safe and warned him not to return to Paris or try to communicate with her.

Between the years 1791 and 1792, more than sixty letters were passed between Fersen and Marie Antoinette, written using either cipher or an invisible, white ink. The cipher was a complicated one and followed the pattern of a polyalphabetic substitution cipher. The manuscripts found